

MGT365 – Section 4  
FUNDAMENTALS OF HUMAN RESOURCE  
MANAGEMENT – Fall 2025  
12/08/2025

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# **I. Introduction**

When our consulting team first initiated the HR Strategic Plan for Shenandoah Valley Investments and Loans Bank (SVILB), a question that arose for us was: *“What if the things we think are problems aren’t actually problems at all, but opportunities we haven’t learned how to use yet?”* That question shaped the direction of our strategic plan as we learned to see advantages in which position the bank was instead of bugs to fix. As we reviewed the bank’s staffing structure and its services, these advantages became clearer to develop. Many of the elements that seemed like weaknesses on the surface, like the unusually high number of hourly employees, the level of part-time staff, the rural branch locations, and the challenges of operating in an area covered with competitors, were not inherently flaws. They were simply pieces of the bank that needed to be reorganized, redirected, or trained differently. As outside consultants, our job was not to remove these pieces, but to reorient them so that they begin working in SVILB’s favor. This approach is rooted in masterful idea of competitive advantage.

A competitive advantage is “Competitive advantage refers to the ways that a company can produce goods or deliver services better than its competitors. It allows a company to achieve superior margins and generate value for the company and its shareholders.” When it comes to competitive advantage, each company has a distinct way of going about it. They are almost impossible to copy. The way our group thought about it was that competitive advantage is like a fingerprint, no two are the same. For a community bank like SVILB, each of us saw that competitive advantage might not exactly come from enormous technology budgets or aggressive urban customer markets. Instead, it comes from using what the bank already has, which is its people, its culture, its community relationships, and its understanding of the Shenandoah Valley. That is the goal of this HR Strategic Plan. Each recommendation we make, from workforce planning to talent acquisition to development, performance, and compensation, is designed to take what seemed like SVILB’s limitations and turn them into our advantage. We are viewing hourly staffing as a source of agility, building pipelines from local schools, investing in problem-solving training, and strengthening diversity, performance management, and compensation systems. In doing this, SVILB can create a workforce that is more skilled, more loyal, and more community-driven than any other bank in the Valley. These recommendations form the roadmap for SVILB to develop its competitive edge, suited to the region it serves.

## **II. HRM Improvements for Six Areas of an Organization**

### **Workforce Planning and Staffing**

As the four of us external consultants have been reviewing SVILB’s workforce, we agreed that one of the best opportunities for improvement is how the bank uses its hourly employees. Instead of viewing the high number of hourly roles as a weakness or something to try

to fix, we believe it can be one of SVILB's biggest strengths. Hourly workers can give flexibility and the ability to learn tasks quickly, which is valuable in the Shenandoah Valley where customer flow can change frequently. One improvement that we recommend is cross-training hourly employees so they can support teller work, account support, or basic loan processing when needed. Patrick saw that in his workplace, cross-training was beneficial. He says, "Onboarding takes a while. When you have someone leave, instead of a 100 percent loss, you can have your bases covered." To make space for part-time workers to be an advantage, to us, minimizing total losses is key. Cole's experience with cross-training is a good example of how flexibility can help an organization. His experience was not from a job but from high school sports. On his football team, Cole was a "jack of all trades" type of player, learning multiple positions on both offense and defense so he could step in wherever he was needed. If someone got hurt or could not play, Cole was able to fill that spot, so the team did not fall apart just because one person was missing. In the same way, when employees in a bank are cross-trained, the organization can keep running effectively even when there are unexpected changes or staffing gaps. The second improvement is similar, creating small groups of hourly employees who rotate among a cluster of nearby branches. We would recommend this route-based staffing system to keep productivity up. Gloria found that F&M Bank reported in 2024 that cross-training rural branch employees helped them reduce service disruptions and increased branch reliability. Their 2024 annual report said, "We reinvested in key areas, such as our branch network, by adding service staff to provide improved customer service." Pendleton Community Bank explained in 2022 that rotating employees based on daily and seasonal branch traffic helped them keep costs down. This approach makes sense in the Shenandoah Valley, where certain branches may get busier during agricultural seasons, waves of tourism, or community events. This would also support SVILB's goal of lowering the Operating Efficiency Ratio from 70.9 percent to 65 percent, which the American Bankers Association described as best achieved through flexible scheduling and multi-role hourly employees. Strengthening how SVILB staffs and schedules its hourly employees is crucial for how the bank attracts and keeps the right people for its positions, which leads into the need for stronger talent acquisition and retention strategies.

## **Talent Acquisition and Retention**

Gloria's research showed that many employers in the Shenandoah Valley rely on local talent pipelines because it helps them build a more loyal workforce. Our group agreed that SVILB can benefit from the same strategy, especially since the bank plans to grow over the next several years. The Virginia Economic Development Partnership noted that work-based learning is one of Virginia's strongest tools for developing committed local employees. This is why we support the idea of building internship pipelines with high schools such as Broadway, East Rock, and Spotswood, as well as colleges like JMU and Blue Ridge, Laurel Ridge, and Mountain Gateway Community Colleges. Programs like FFA also prepare students to work with agricultural customers. The National FFA Organization wrote in 2024 that its programs help students build "career readiness and industry-specific knowledge," which might be especially

useful for a bank serving farm communities. These partnerships would give SVILB consistent access to entry-level candidates who already understand the Valley's culture and economy. Our group also looked at how other regional banks manage turnover. Summit Community Bank reported in 2023 that retention improved after the bank emphasized internal mobility opportunities for frontline hourly staff. SVILB already has many hourly positions that could grow into higher-level roles with the right programs. We found that SVILB could create the right development programs, offering paid certifications for hourly workers and guaranteeing predictable scheduling. Not only did our textbook this emphasize intensely, but SHRM's 2022 research shows that developmental opportunities are one of the top reasons hourly workers stay with an employer. SHRM said in 2022 that, "Workers need more skills development opportunities and their employers know it, according to the index: 49 percent of employees want to develop their skills but don't know where to begin." From each of our own personal experiences living in the Valley, we know that people prefer long-term, community-focused jobs where they can build a stable life. SVILB has an opportunity to offer exactly that. This connects to the next priority, which is giving these workers strong, practical training so they can succeed in their roles long-term and deliver the service the Valley expects from a community bank.

## **Employee Training & Development**

Our group concluded that improving employee training is essential if SVILB wants to reduce customer attrition by half within the next five years. Gloria found that Park View Federal Credit Union explained in its 2023 highlights that investing in member experience training "increased satisfaction across agricultural and family accounts." F&M Bank described in 2023 how agricultural customer-service training helped them "strengthen relationships in rural communities." Strong training programs matter in small communities like the Shenandoah Valley, where people value being recognized, being treated well, and working with staff who understand local needs. SVILB can build a training program focused on practical problem-solving, digital banking skills, small-business support, and clear communication. Deloitte explained in 2023 that "clear advancement pathways increase retention among hourly employees," which is going to fit the culture of the Valley where people prefer stable work with room to grow. Cole noted that in his workplace at Dick's Sporting Goods, he had also seen that employees are more motivated when they have a clear next step to work toward. SVILB can use this same approach by offering promotions such as Lead Teller or Customer Solutions Specialist to employees who complete certain modules. Investing in the individual employee and their future is a great first step for creating an environment where inclusion and diversity can genuinely grow.

## **Promoting Diversity & Inclusion**

As a community bank, SVILB should be representative of the community it serves. The SVILB service area includes the highest agricultural producing regions in the state. Rockingham,

Augusta, Rockbridge, Shenandoah, and Page counties account for over 20% of the state's agricultural production and \$1.3 Billion in sales annually. The SVILB service area includes four vocational training schools, one Governors School, and three community colleges that enroll local high school students. In addition, the local area is home to James Madison University, Bridgewater College, and Eastern Mennonite University, each with majors in the financial services industry whose graduates often stay in the area after graduation and bring a more diversity of experience to the Valley that complements the local population. The combination of agricultural experience, access to educational programs, and a steady labor pool of educated professionals provides an opportunity for SVILB to partner with and create a training pipeline to attract, hire, and train local candidates for leading roles in the planned expansion.

Many of the local students that attend colleges or universities major in agricultural, health care, or education programs. Therefore, to integrate into the community more deeply, we recommend that SVILB management aggressively seek what would be considered non-traditional candidates for leadership roles within the institution through programs such as the FFA. The creation of a robust program to build a training pipeline starting in the local high school vocational schools and continuing into the Virginia Community College System is a primary focus of the diversity and inclusion program at SVILB. Drawing candidates from a farming community with experience in the agricultural industry will give a competitive advantage over other banking institutions in the area that do not have the firsthand experiences to create the connections with the SVILB clients. As a community bank that hires from within the community it serves, it develops deeper ties to the community and reduces costs while expanding the labor pool by leveraging the personal networks of staff.

To illustrate the value of personal networks in creating employment opportunities, LeeAnne and Gloria were able to leverage their networks to recruit classmates into positions at ALKU as the business unit expanded on campus. Though they come from different majors and backgrounds, through their programs of study they were able to identify members of their cohort that fit the company's culture and had the drive to succeed. Similarly, hiring locally for leadership positions at SVILB will use existing personal and professional networks to place the best employees in the most appropriate positions more cost-effectively. By hiring from the networks of existing staff, the institution reduces the risk of the unknown as potential hires are already known to employees. Relocation costs are reduced when a local hiring pool is utilized, and by using the local educational institutions as partners, SVILB management ensures cultural fit within the institution. As stated, the focus on recruiting locally has significant financial advantages. There are other, equally significant intangible advantages that are gained by building trust within the community as the employer of preference.

## **Performance Management**

To assist in reducing employee turnover, historical performance management data will be used to identify common areas of concern. Utilizing the program partnerships, SVILB leadership will work closely with the Vocational Schools and Community Colleges to work with professors and course creators to build course work that focuses on identified areas of concern. Combining coursework with a wide range of internships will ensure that students can practically apply academic knowledge in real-world situations. This will shorten the onboarding process at SVILB and save considerable financial and training resources to focus on emerging technologies once fully employed at a branch.

In addition to the standard annual reviews, we recommend that SVILB utilize a performance management program deployed by the US Military Senior Enlisted Academy referred to as a “Performance 365” wherein every supervisory element conducts a daily check-in with their direct report. This ensures constant feedback, up and down the chain of command, is addressed daily. Patrick utilized this method while serving in the US Navy onboard ships and shore installations. He stated that this not only improved performance significantly but also identified and resolved small concerns with staff before they grew into bigger problems. It has the added benefit of making sure supervisors are engaged with their staff and staff are comfortable giving and receiving feedback.

At SVILB, fostering an inclusive environment with engaged leadership, opportunity for growth and advancement, and prioritizing work/life balance will reduce turnover significantly. Building a reputation as a community begins with treating our employees as valued members of our community. In addition to the cost savings from lowering churn, employees that feel they are valued, treated with dignity and respect, and compensated fairly are more likely to refer their friends and family to SVILB for employment and banking needs.

## **Compensation & Benefits**

We recommend that SVILB continue with the current pay structure and continue to offer competitive wages based on the labor market data. However, we recommend that SVILB look beyond wages alone and view compensation more holistically. As noted by SHRM, pay and compensation are ranked as the sixth most common reason that people leave their jobs. Therefore, we recommend that SVILB widen their compensation schemes to include employee referral bonuses, expand internships and cross training opportunities, and offer tuition assistance/reimbursement programs.

With the goal of being a community bank serving the community by members of the community, an employee referral bonus program will ensure that a steady supply of applicants is always within the accession pipeline. Many local industries and companies utilize this program, such as Pilgrim's Pride (poultry producer), Danone North America (dairy producer), Sysco Foods (foodservice supplier), and others with great results. According to a talent acquisition specialist at Sysco Foods in Harrisonburg, Jane Doe, nearly 60% of their hourly employees come from current employee referrals, and those candidates stay with Sysco on average 40% longer than unaffiliated new hires. She further said that they save significant costs as jobs are often filled by referrals before they are posted on job search sites.

Creating paid internships with students at Vocational schools and the community colleges will make SVILB an employer of choice for local students that are more likely to stay in the geographic area during school and post-graduation. Incentivizing high school students interested in the financial services industry with paid internships builds a deeper bench of potential future executives within SVILB. Fully integrating young people into the company culture of SVILB will pay dividends in employee loyalty and longevity as well as ensuring the culture of the bank remains relevant to the community it serves. This will give SVILB a competitive advantage as it expands into the smaller communities of the Shenandoah Valley that have lost traditional community employers due to increased globalization.

With lower median incomes than other more affluent areas in the state, offering tuition assistance and tuition reimbursement programs is a valuable tool for recruiting and retaining the best candidates. We recommend using a model similar to the one used by Sentara Health and others. The institution will pay for continuing education in sectors with open positions up to the average cost of the program. Upon completion of the course of study, SVILB will reimburse the employee 4.2% per month of the cost of the program. Therefore, if the employee stays with SVILB for 24 months post-graduation, the entire cost of the education or training will be reimbursed. This means that SVILB will not only have a more qualified and highly trained employee but also incentivize them to remain for two years, allowing the institution to enjoy the return on investment while amortizing the costs over years.

### **III. Introduction to SWOT Analysis**

When working to develop our Human Resources Strategic Plan for Shenandoah Valley Investments and Loans Bank, our team began by completing a SWOT Analysis of the organization. Chapter 2 of our HRM textbook explains how essential it is to complete a SWOT Analysis when determining which strategic choices an organization should prioritize. This structure will lead to SVILB successfully fulfilling the goals outlined in our strategic plan. The Corporate Finance Institute describes a SWOT Analysis as one of the most useful tools in strategic planning. With this guidance in mind, LeeAnne, Gloria, Patrick, and Cole collaborated to effectively develop a clear SWOT Analysis that will guide our HR strategic plan.

## **Strengths**

Beginning with the strengths, we felt that Shenandoah Valley Investments and Loans Bank had many worth mentioning. First, this company has \$500 million in assets, which shows financial stability as well as the opportunity for continued growth. The average bank asset size in rural areas is roughly \$187 million, showing that SVILB has an advantage over the average competitor. While our goal is to continuously increase the amount of assets SVILB holds, we believe it's a strategic advantage to already have such a strong financial base.

Another major strength SVILB has is the benefits package it offers to employees. Shenandoah Valley Investments and Loans Bank offers dental, vision, and healthcare insurance as well as 401(k) and paid time off. A key factor that makes the benefits package so competitive is the fact that it's offered to part-time employees, attracting long-term part-time talent as well. This comprehensive benefits plan is highly competitive, which will attract and retain highly talented employees. Chapter 13 of our HRM textbook explains how much employers can impact the economic stability of their employees based on the benefits package they provide. SVILB offers employees a very attractive benefits package that will relieve some of the economic stressors their employees feel. This can increase employee well-being and commitment to the company.

Our group also identified the bank's employee pay structure as another strength, with 65% of SVILB's employees being paid hourly. Although our group initially believed this fact may be a weakness, we learned from Monica Matherly that this could actually provide SVILB with more control over labor costs, thus being a strength. Having this control means the Shenandoah Valley Investments and Loans Bank can adjust costs based on operational needs.

The last strength our team discussed is how SVILB already has HR practices in place that align well with the bank's broader business goals. This shows that the culture at Shenandoah Valley Investments and Loans Bank places value on clear communication and coordinated efforts across departments. This alignment and culture of SVILB directly contributes to the growth and long-term success of the business. This also ensures that every HR decision directly supports the long-term growth and improvement goals of the company. It also positions the Shenandoah Investments and Loans Bank well for implementing more advanced HR strategies.

## **Weaknesses**

In regards to the weaknesses of the Shenandoah Valley Investments and Loans Bank, our team identified three main contributors. The first weakness is the amount of local competition that exists within the Shenandoah Valley region. There are about 60 banks in the city of Harrisonburg alone, and the broader Valley encompasses about 10 cities total. Due to the high concentration of financial institutions in the surrounding region, SVILB faces high competition



for customers and talent. This geographic factor also negatively impacts the type of clientele SVILB is able to reach, making it difficult to expand outside of the Shenandoah Valley area.

Another weakness SVILB has is the part-time to full-time employee ratio. With 60 part-time employees, SVILB relies a lot on part-time staffing which negatively affects how much these workers can contribute to the company, customers, and leadership opportunities. Part-time workers also have higher turnover rates because they have a weaker commitment to the organization. Overall this amount of part-time workers creates challenges when trying to maintain strong customer relationships and offer employee training for advancement, both being crucial to SVILB's long-term strategic goals.

A final weakness we identified is the Shenandoah Investments and Loans Bank's need to hire an external team to develop an HR Strategic Plan. While this shows a willingness to improve, it also suggests that the current HR systems most likely are not meeting the goals outlined by the company. Reaching out to outside consultants shows that SVILB may lack internal experience in strategic HR management. Our HRM textbook shows research supporting the need to have executives closely involved in strategy formulation, so as we lay out our implementation plan we will need to ensure that this is something SVILB are practicing. This might not have been happening before, which could've contributed to the need for outside assistance.

## **Opportunities**

When our group was discussing the Shenandoah Valley Investments and Loans Bank, we thought of many opportunities it could use to gain a competitive advantage against other local banks in the valley. With the development in the area attracting not just new residents but also more businesses, this will increase the demand for loans for businesses and residents as the area continues to grow. This growth not only gives the bank the opportunity to gain new clients but also helps deepen the relationship between existing customers. They can do this by offering them more relationship banking services and targeted financial education. Relationship banking is when a bank focuses on building more of a long-term client instead of just one and done. They want to be able to understand the client's needs and then offer the right advice and services. A targeted financial education is when banks offer tips that are catered to individual clients instead of one that fits all. By getting to know the clients more on a personal level and understanding their needs. The bank can recommend the right mix of products and services and by doing this it can increase the customers' satisfaction rate and really keep them from leaving for a new bank. An example of this would be if a client already has an account with the bank, they can help them with a car loan or even a small business line of credit. This turns a weak relationship into a strong one by having multiple products with that customer.

Another opportunity for SVILB is to gain reliable employees by partnering with local colleges and universities like James Madison University, they could also do this with local high schools for seniors. By doing these partnerships, it can create a structured internship pipeline and early career hiring programs that can help the bank bring younger employees who already have basic knowledge of the bank like their culture and how they operate. With this pipeline it will eventually lower recruiting costs because the bank does not have to use as many resources to find qualified people to work for them. Internship programs also help the bank with building a stronger relationship with the surrounding area because it gives students real world experience. Another way to help build a better reputation in the area is to cater to the working class by having bank hours longer. The reason for this is because many people in the area work long days and might not have the opportunity to come into the bank and have a face-to-face conversation with an employee. By having more flexibility hours, it will bring in more clients and keep those existing ones.

If SVILB narrows the products that they offer to a more of a customer focused level like loans, basic investment options for clients and services that are not for large companies but for small to medium sized ones. By doing this, it also helps the bank by keeping everything tight and not stretching their resources too thin. The bank might not have a large array of options for clients, but those services that they do provide will be done well and effectively. Many small businesses need help with startup capital, equipment loans and lines of credit and really focusing on those areas helps the bank stand out from the competition which will make entrepreneurs come to their bank instead of the others. For the customers, SVILB can focus on more straightforward products rather than over-the-top complicated ones. One of the most important opportunities that the team talked about was that SVILB has is if they are able to reduce expenses by improving the operating efficiency ratio, then the bank will be able to redirect the money they saved into different areas that need more funds. A few examples of this would be investing in better technology, training programs, and marketing. A bank with a lower efficiency ratio when compared to their competitors shows how they are more agile and better managed.

## **Threats**

The Shenandoah Valley Investment and loans Bank also has a lot of threats that can impact the bank. With the development of the area, it also brings in more competition. More banks and other institutions are making their way into the valley. This can saturate the already thin area. If the Shenandoah Valley Investment and Loans Bank want to maintain their competitive advantage against the other banks, they need to figure out how to improve their customer service, use better tools, and have more flexible products. If the competition offers lower fees and better service, then potential and current customers will leave for those banks.

The bank deals with very high attrition for both clients and employees. If the Shenandoah Valley Investment and loans Bank wants to maintain a competitive advantage, they need to figure out how to deal with customers and employees' satisfaction. If employers cannot keep

employees from leaving the company, this causes the company to have a negative culture. New employees will be rushed to fill in the spots that are missing and when this happens, the employees want to understand the values that the bank wants to have. Also, if you keep training employees it will affect customer service. The reason for this is that training takes a lot of time and resources which will take away from having quality service. If employees do not know how to handle customers correctly then those customers will find another bank that they feel welcomed. When you have a high attrition rate, it impacts morale in a negative way for employees, which causes them to be less motivated and perform worse. Cole believes that once you solve the employee satisfaction problem it will work its way down to improving customer satisfaction as well.

One of the biggest threats that our group thinks the Shenandoah Valley Investment and Loans Bank faces is the economic downturn. This affects how customers borrow money, and it's also hard for them to pay off existing loans. This will increase the losses for the bank. It can also slow down the growth of the bank by having higher standards regarding who they loan. Expanding into new areas within the valley, it can strain their resources as well. Many of the branches will not be able to maintain operational efficiency and high-quality customer service when your resources are stretched too thin. This will cause different branches to experience different results at an inconsistent level which will make customers leave to find a more reliable bank.

## **IV. Conclusion**

The Shenandoah Valley Investments and Loans Bank is uniquely positioned to take advantage of the unique opportunity that the Shenandoah Valley offers. Despite competition across the region, focusing on becoming a community bank institution that specializes in and caters to the needs of an agricultural community gives them the advantage in the age of large, international banking. As one of the smaller institutions, SVILB can move more quickly to respond to the changing market conditions and offer more personalized banking products to its customers. By utilizing a local workforce with experience in the primary industries across the SVILB service area, the bank can build trust and credibility with the clientele and reduce customer attrition. By becoming a partner with vocational schools and the community colleges, SVILB can shape curriculum to ensure graduates have the identified knowledge, skills, and abilities to meet the needs of customers while being an employer of choice.

Initially, the lack of resources that the global institutions have seemed like a disadvantage, it revealed an opportunity that SVILB could use to build their competitive advantage in the Shenandoah Valley. As a smaller institution, SVILB is able to make decisions more quickly and will have closer ties to the communities they serve. With a history of paying competitive wages but increasing partnerships with localities, credibility and trust increases, which is an important cultural value in the Shenandoah Valley. Ensuring that branch and regional leadership is drawn from the community mitigates threats from larger institutions that are not as connected with those communities. As a lending institution, economic downturns are

always a significant risk. However, clients are less likely to default when they know the people they are borrowing from and having loan officers familiar with agricultural communities, SVILB will be better able to forecast and predict trends that technology may not be able to foresee.

By making a commitment to becoming an integral member of the community it serves, SVILB can use its institutional knowledge to become the premier community banking institution. The institution will reflect the community and leverage that to build and maintain client base, decrease attrition and accession costs, and allow the institution to rapidly respond to needs within the service area. Thoughtful and considered expansion into rural areas will reap rewards as SVILB becomes a generational community bank.

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